



IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

SECURITY



Google took a month to shut down Catwatchful, a phone spyware operation hosted on its servers

Zack Whittaker — 9:25 AM PDT · July 25, 2025

Google has suspended the account of phone surveillance operator Catwatchful, which was using the tech giant’s servers to host and operate the monitoring software.

Google’s move to shut down the spyware operation comes a month after [TechCrunch alerted the technology giant](#) the operator was hosting the operation on Firebase, one of Google’s developer platforms. Catwatchful relied on Firebase to host and store vast amounts of data stolen from thousands of phones compromised by its spyware.

“We’ve investigated these reported Firebase operations and suspended them for violating our terms of service,” Google spokesperson Ed Fernandez told TechCrunch in an email this week.

When asked by TechCrunch, Google would not say why it took a month to investigate and suspend the operation’s Firebase account. The company’s [own terms of use](#) broadly prohibit its customers from hosting malicious software or spyware operations on its platforms. As a for-profit company, Google has a commercial interest in retaining customers who pay for its services.

As of Friday, Catwatchful is no longer functioning nor does it appear to transmit or receive data, according to a network traffic analysis of the spyware carried out by TechCrunch.

Catwatchful was an Android-specific spyware that presented itself as a child-monitoring app “undetectable” to the user. Much like other phone spyware apps, Catwatchful required its customers to physically install it on a person’s phone, which usually requires prior knowledge of their passcode. These monitoring apps are often called [“stalkerware” \(or spouseware\)](#) for their propensity to be used for non-consensual surveillance of spouses and romantic partners, which is illegal.

Once installed, the app was designed to stay hidden from the victim’s home screen, and upload the victim’s private messages, photos, location data, and more to a web dashboard viewable by the person who planted the app.

TechCrunch first learned of Catwatchful in mid-June after [security researcher Eric Daigle identified a security bug](#) that was exposing the spyware operation’s back-end database.

The bug allowed unauthenticated access to the database, meaning no passwords or credentials were needed to see the data inside. The database contained more than 62,000 Catwatchful customer email addresses and plaintext passwords, as well as records on 26,000 victim devices compromised by the spyware.

The data also exposed the administrator behind the operation, a Uruguay-based developer called Omar Soca Charcov. TechCrunch contacted Charcov to ask if he was aware of the security lapse, or if he planned to notify affected individuals about the breach. Charcov did not respond.

With no clear indication that Charcov would disclose the breach, TechCrunch provided a copy of the Catwatchful database to [data breach](#)

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[notification service Have I Been Pwned](#).

Catwatchful is the latest in a long list of surveillance operations that have experienced a data breach in recent years, in large part due to shoddy coding and poor cybersecurity practices. Catwatchful is by TechCrunch's count [the fifth spyware operation this year](#) to have spilled users' data, and the most recent entry in a list of more than two-dozen known spyware operations since 2017 that have exposed their banks of data.

As we noted [in our previous story](#): Android users can identify if the Catwatchful spyware is installed, even if the app is hidden, by dialing **543210** into your Android phone app's keypad and pressing the call button.

Remember to have [a safety plan in place](#) before removing spyware from your phone.

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If you or someone you know needs help, the National Domestic Violence Hotline (1-800-799-7233) provides 24/7 free, confidential support to victims of domestic abuse and violence. If you are in an emergency situation, call 911. The [Coalition Against Stalkerware](#) has resources if you think your phone has been compromised by spyware.

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Data breach at stalkerware SpyX affects close to 2 million, including thousands of Apple users

Zack Whittaker — 3:30 PM PDT · March 19, 2025

A consumer-grade spyware operation called SpyX was hit by a data breach last year, TechCrunch has learned. The breach reveals that SpyX and two other related mobile apps leaked data on almost 2 million people at the time of the breach, including thousands of Apple users.

The data breach dates back to June 2024 but had not been previously reported, and there is no indication that SpyX's operators ever notified its customers or those targeted by the spyware.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

The SpyX family of mobile spyware is now, by our count, [the 25th mobile surveillance operation since 2017](#) known to have experienced a data breach, or otherwise spilled or exposed their victims' or users' data, showing that the consumer-grade spyware industry continues to proliferate and put people's private data at risk.

The breach also provides a rare look at how [stalkerware](#) like SpyX can also target Apple customers.

Troy Hunt, who runs data breach notification site [Have I Been Pwned](#), received a copy of the breached data in the form of two text files, which contained 1.97 million unique account records with associated email addresses.

Hunt said the vast majority of the email addresses are associated with SpyX. The cache also includes less than 300,000 email addresses associated with two near-identical clones of the SpyX app called Msafely and SpyPhone.

About 40% of the email addresses were already in Have I Been Pwned, Hunt said.

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As with previous spyware breaches, Hunt marked the SpyX data breach in Have I Been Pwned as [“sensitive,”](#) which allows only the person with an affected email address to see if their information is part of this breach.

The operators behind SpyX did not respond to emails from TechCrunch with questions about the breach, and a WhatsApp number listed on SpyX’s website returned a message saying it was not registered with the messaging app.

Another spyware, another breach

SpyX is billed as mobile monitoring software for Android and Apple devices, ostensibly for granting parental control of a child’s phone.

Surveillance malware, like SpyX, also goes by the term [stalkerware](#) (and spouseware) because sometimes the operators explicitly promote their products as a way to spy on a spouse or domestic partner, which is broadly illegal without that person’s knowledge. Even when the operators don’t explicitly promote this illegal use, spyware apps share much of the same stealthy data-stealing capabilities.

Consumer-grade spyware, like stalkerware, usually works in one of two ways.

Apps that work on Android devices, including SpyX, are typically downloaded from outside of the official Google Play app store and require someone with physical access to a victim’s device — usually with knowledge of their passcode — to weaken its security settings and plant the spyware.

Apple has stricter rules about which apps can be on the App Store and run on iPhones and iPads, so stalkerware usually taps into a copy of the device’s backup found on Apple’s cloud storage service, iCloud. With a person’s iCloud credentials, stalkerware can continuously download the victim’s most recent backup directly from Apple’s servers. iCloud backups [store the majority](#) of a person’s device data, including messages, photos, and app data.

According to Hunt, one of the two files in the breached cache referred to iCloud in its filename and contained about 17,000 distinct sets of plaintext Apple Account usernames and passwords.

Since the iCloud credentials in the breached cache clearly belonged to Apple customers, Hunt sought to confirm the authenticity of the data by reaching out to Have I Been Pwned subscribers whose Apple Account email addresses and passwords were found in the data. Hunt said several people confirmed that the information he provided was accurate.

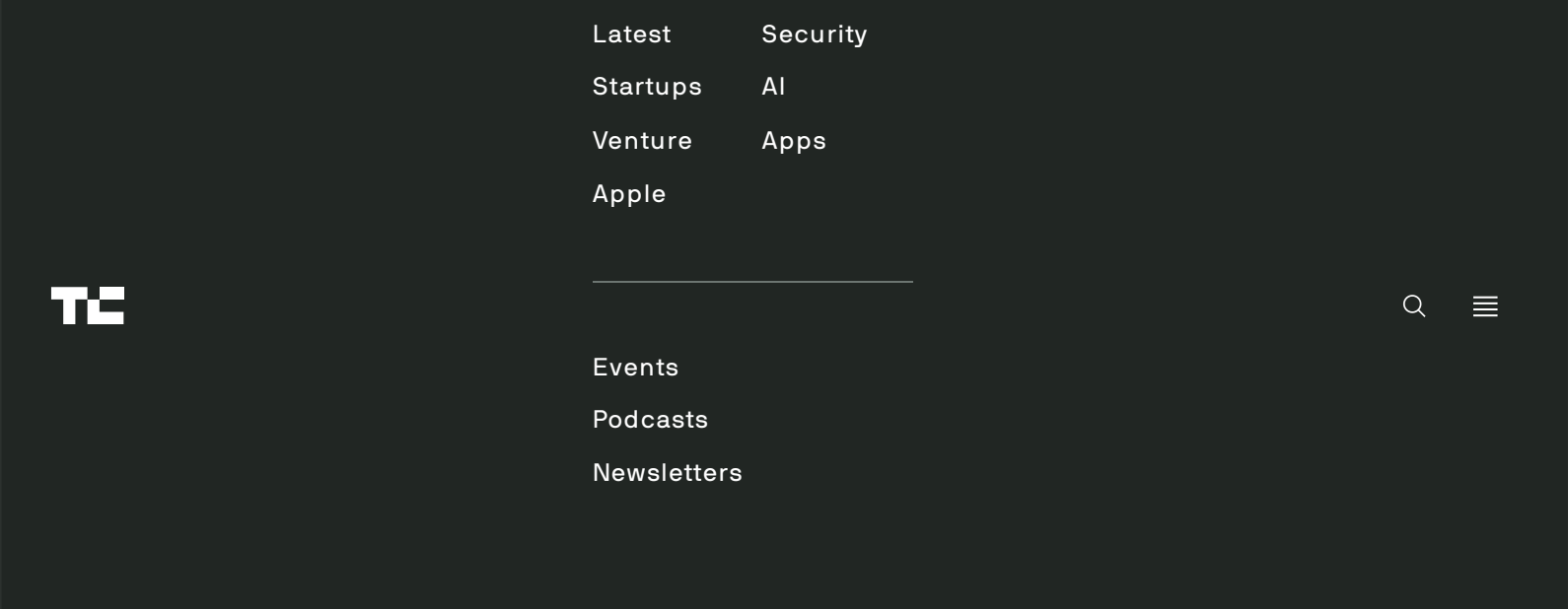
Given the possibility of an ongoing risk to victims whose account credentials might still be valid, Hunt provided the list of breached iCloud credentials to Apple prior to publication.

Apple did not comment by press time when reached by TechCrunch prior to publication.

In a brief statement provided after publication, Apple spokesperson Sarah O'Rourke told TechCrunch: "When data breaches at other companies pose a risk to Apple accounts, our security teams work to rapidly investigate and protect our users. In this case, fewer than 250 iCloud users were impacted, and we immediately secured their accounts."

As for the rest of the email addresses and passwords found in the breached text files, it was less clear if these were working credentials for any service other than SpyX and its clone apps.

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may alert the person who planted it.

For Android users, switching on [Google Play Protect](#) is a useful security feature that can help to protect against Android malware, including unwanted phone surveillance apps. You can enable Google Play from the app's settings if it isn't already enabled.

Google accounts are far more protected with [two-factor authentication](#), which can better protect against account and data intrusions. Know [what steps to take if your Google account is compromised](#).

If you have an iPhone and iPad, you can check and [remove any devices from your account that you don't recognize](#). You should ensure that your Apple account uses a long and unique password ([ideally saved in a password manager](#)) and that your account also has [two-factor authentication switched on](#). You should also change your iPhone or iPad passcode if you think someone may have physically compromised your device.

If you or someone you know needs help, the National Domestic Violence Hotline (1-800-799-7233) provides 24/7 free, confidential support to victims of domestic abuse and violence. If you are in an emergency situation, call 911. The [Coalition Against Stalkerware](#) has resources if you think your phone has been compromised by spyware.

Updated with comment from Apple.

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Data breach reveals Catwatchful ‘stalkerware’ is spying on thousands of phones

Zack Whittaker — 7:05 AM PDT · July 2, 2025

A security vulnerability in a stealthy Android spyware operation called Catwatchful has exposed thousands of its customers, including its administrator.

The bug, which was discovered by security researcher Eric Daigle, spilled the spyware app’s full database of email addresses and plaintext passwords that Catwatchful customers use to access the data stolen from the phones of their victims.

Catwatchful is spyware masquerading as a child monitoring app that claims to be “invisible and cannot be detected,” all the while uploading the victim’s phone’s private contents to a dashboard viewable by the person who planted the app. The stolen data includes the victims’ photos, messages, and real-time location data. The app can also remotely tap into the live ambient audio from the phone’s microphone and access both front and rear phone cameras.

Spyware apps like Catwatchful are banned from the app stores and rely on being downloaded and planted by someone with physical access to a person’s phone. As such, these apps are commonly referred to as “[stalkerware](#)” (or [spouseware](#)) for their propensity to facilitate non-consensual surveillance of spouses and romantic partners, which is illegal.

Catwatchful is the latest example in a growing list of stalkerware operations that have been hacked, breached, or otherwise exposed the data they obtain, and is [at least the fifth spyware operation this year](#) to have experienced a data spill. The incident shows that consumer-grade spyware continues to proliferate, despite being prone to shoddy coding and security failings that expose both paying customers and unsuspecting victims to data breaches.

According to a copy of the database from early June, which TechCrunch has seen, Catwatchful had email addresses and passwords on more than 62,000 customers and the phone data from 26,000 victims’ devices.

Most of the compromised devices were located in Mexico, Colombia, India, Peru, Argentina, Ecuador, and Bolivia (in order of the number of victims). Some of the records date back to 2018, the data shows.

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The Catwatchful database also revealed the identity of the spyware operation's administrator, Omar Soca Charcov, a developer based in Uruguay. Charcov opened our emails, but did not respond to our requests for comment sent in both English and Spanish. TechCrunch asked if he was aware of the Catwatchful data breach, and if he plans to disclose the incident to its customers.

Without any clear indication that Charcov will disclose the incident, TechCrunch provided a copy of the Catwatchful database to data breach notification service [Have I Been Pwned](#).

Catwatchful hosting spyware data on Google's servers

Daigle, a security researcher in Canada who [has previously investigated stalkerware abuses](#), detailed his findings in a [blog post](#).

According to Daigle, Catwatchful uses a custom-made API, which every one of the planted Android apps relies on to communicate with and send data to Catwatchful's servers. The spyware also uses Google's Firebase, a web and mobile development platform, to host and store the victim's stolen phone data, including their photos and ambient audio recordings.

Daigle told TechCrunch that the API was unauthenticated, allowing anyone on the internet to interact with the Catwatchful user database without needing a login, which exposed the entire Catwatchful database of customer email addresses and passwords.

When contacted by TechCrunch, the web company hosting the Catwatchful API suspended the spyware developer's account, briefly blocking the spyware from operating, but the API returned later on HostGator. A spokesperson for HostGator, Kristen Andrews, did not respond to requests for comment regarding the company hosting the spyware's operations.

TechCrunch confirmed that Catwatchful uses Firebase by downloading and installing the Catwatchful spyware on a virtualized Android device, which allows us to run the spyware in an isolated sandbox without giving it any real-world data, like our location.

We examined the network traffic flowing in and out of the device, which showed data from the phone uploading to a specific Firebase instance used by Catwatchful to host the victim's stolen data.

After TechCrunch provided Google with copies of the Catwatchful malware, Google said it added new protections for [Google Play Protect](#), a security tool that scans Android phones for malicious apps, like spyware. Now, Google Play Protect will alert users when it detects the Catwatchful spyware or its installer on a user's phone.

TechCrunch also provided Google with details of the Firebase instance involved in storing data for the Catwatchful operation. Asked whether the stalkerware operation violates Firebase's terms of service, Google told

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TechCrunch on June 25 that it was investigating but would not immediately commit to taking down the operation.

“All apps using Firebase products must abide by our terms of service and privacy policies. We are investigating this particular issue, and if we determine it is in violation, appropriate action will be taken. Android apps that are not installed these apps are protected by Google Play Protect. I am not a spokesperson for Google.

As of publication, Catwatchful remains hosted on Firebase.

Opsec mistake exposes spyware administrator

Like many spyware operations, Catwatchful does not publicly list its owner or disclose who runs the operation. It’s [not uncommon for stalkerware and spyware operators to hide their real identities](#), given the legal and reputational risks associated with facilitating illegal surveillance.

But an [operational security](#) mishap in the dataset exposed Charcov as the operation’s administrator.

A review of the Catwatchful database lists Charcov as the first record in one of the files in the dataset. (In past spyware-related data breaches, some operators have been identified by early records in the database, as oftentimes the developers are testing the spyware product on their own devices.)

The dataset included Charcov’s full name, phone number, and the web address of the specific Firebase instance where Catwatchful’s database is stored on Google’s servers.

Charcov’s personal email address, found in the dataset, is the same email that he lists on his LinkedIn page, which has since been set to private. Charcov also configured his Catwatchful administrator’s email address as the password recovery address on his personal email account in the event he gets locked out, which directly links Charcov to the Catwatchful operation.

How to remove Catwatchful spyware

While Catwatchful claims it “cannot be uninstalled,” there are ways to detect and remove the app from an affected device.

Before you start, it’s important to have [a safety plan in place](#), as disabling spyware can alert the person who planted it. The [Coalition Against Stalkerware](#) does important work in this space and has resources to help victims and survivors.

Android users can detect Catwatchful, even if it is hidden from view, by dialing **543210** into your Android phone app’s keypad and then hitting the call button. If Catwatchful is installed, the app should appear on your screen. This

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code is a built-in [backdoor feature](#) that allows whoever planted the app to regain access to the settings once the app is hidden. This code can also be used by anyone to see if the app is installed.

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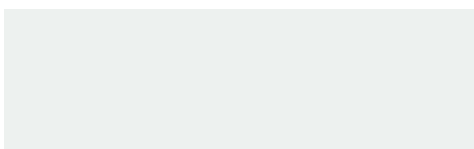
As for removing the app, TechCrunch has a [general how-to guide for removing Android spyware](#) that can help you identify and remove common types of phone stalkerware, and then enable the various settings you need to secure your Android device.

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If you or someone you know needs help, the National Domestic Violence Hotline (1-800-799-7233) provides 24/7 free, confidential support to victims of domestic abuse and violence. If you are in an emergency situation, call 911. The [Coalition Against Stalkerware](#) has resources if you think your phone has been compromised by spyware.

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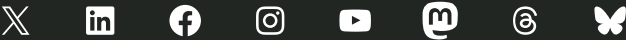
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